College of Social and Behavioral Sciences
Master of Arts in Clinical Mental Health Counseling
COUN 5453 Psychopathology and Diagnosis
Spring 2026

Instructor:

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Office Hours:
By Appointment

Class Schedule:

1. **Friday, January 9, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm**
2. Tuesday, January 13, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm
3. Tuesday, January 27, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm
4. Tuesday, February 10, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm
5. Tuesday, February 24, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm
6. Tuesday, March 10, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm
7. Tuesday, March 24, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm
8. Tuesday, April 7, 2026 - 6:00 pm to 10:00 pm

Required Text:

1. American Psychiatric Association. (2022). Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, DSM-5-TR (5th Edition). Washington, D.C: American Psychiatric Publishing. ISBN 978-0-89042-576-3

2. Castonguay, L. G., & Oltmanns, T. F. (Eds.). (2021). Psychopathology: From Science to Clinical Practice (Second edition). The Guilford Press. ISBN 9781462547616

3. Morrison, J. (2016) The First Interview (4th edition) New York, New York. The Guildford Press. ISBN 9781462529834

Course Description:

This course focuses on the diagnosis process, differential diagnosis, and treatment of the psychopathologies and how those pathologies differ in various cultures. Emphasis is placed on the use of the current Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM).

Course Objectives:

- Apply processes of differential diagnosis using the DSM.
- Evaluate cultural and spiritual differences in definitions of psychopathology.
- Integrate understanding of psychopathology with counseling theory and practice.

CACREP Standards:

5C.1.c principles, models, … of biopsychosocial case conceptualization …

5C.2.b etiology, nomenclature, … of mental and emotional disorders

5C.2.d diagnostic process, including differential diagnosis and the use of current diagnostic classification systems, including the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM) and the International Classification of Diseases (ICD)

5C.3.a intake interview, mental status evaluation, biopsychosocial history, mental health history, …

CACREP Standards (cont.):

Outcomes	**Measurement**			
Objectives	*Vignettes*	*Final Exam*	*Diagnostic Interview Assignment*	*Course Reading*
5C.1.c		*X*		*X*
5C.2.b	X	X		X
5C.2.d	X	X	X	X
5C.3.a	X	X		X

KPI Addressed

7. Diagnostic Systems (Introduction)- Utilize differential diagnostic process and systems
The final exam in the course is the key assessment for this KPI.

Academic Honesty:

Northwest University expects honesty from students in all areas, including their academic lives. Academic dishonesty is a serious violation of university standards and may result in the students' receiving an "F" on the assignment, receiving an "F" for the course, or possibly being dismissed from the University. Instances of academic dishonesty are coordinated through the respective graduate program office and typically reported to the Provost's Office.

Academic dishonesty includes cheating on assignments or examinations, submitting the same (or essentially the same) paper in more than one course without prior consent of the current assigning professor(s), sabotaging another student's work, and plagiarizing. Plagiarism is "using

someone else's ideas or phrasing and representing those ideas or phrasing as our own, either on purpose or through carelessness" (MLA). Any student disciplined by a faculty member for alleged academic dishonesty has the right to appeal the disciplinary action. The student should initiate his/her appeal according to procedures outlined in the Northwest University Student Academic Appeals Policy, which is available in the Provost Office.

Attendance Policy:
Class attendance is extremely important for student learning and achievement of specified course outcomes and, in turn, the program aims. Hence, attendance at all class sessions is expected. At minimum, students absent for a class session will need to make up any missed assignments or exercises and complete the expected readings. A grade penalty will be applied if more than one class session is missed. Additional policies and consequences are at the discretion of the individual professor of the course. More than one missed class session will result in failure of the course and require a retake to continue in the program. In this circumstance, the student is encouraged to withdraw from the course and retake the class when it is offered again. In the event of unusual circumstances (e.g., extended illness, emergency), a student may appeal the automatic course failure. A proposal outlining a plan for satisfactory course completion will be required, composed by the professor and agreed to by the student. In addition, the plan will require approval by the program director and Dean.

Disability Accommodations and Procedures:
For students with learning differences and/or physical disabilities, as defined by the ADA and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, Northwest University takes an individual and holistic approach to providing accommodations. Accommodations are developed and approved on an individual basis by the Student Development Office, not the CMHC program or individual faculty members. Students needing accommodations for a diagnosed disability should follow the procedures provided on the Student Development Office's website for disability accommodations.

Communication Policy:
Timely communication between the professor and students is important to the overall functioning of the program. Therefore, both students and faculty should respond to email or phone messages within two business days. If the professor is out-of-office, he or she should have an automatic reply message (on email) or voicemail recording (phone) providing the date of his/her return, as well as an in-office contact for urgent requests.

Grading Policy:
Grading is conducted on the Discovery Grade Book page of the course. Students are expected to monitor their progress accordingly. Assignments and tests will generally be graded within two weeks. Final papers and projects may take up to three weeks. The professor will let you know if there are exceptional circumstances preventing a timely return of grades. If you have concerns about grading timing, please check with the professor, program coordinator, or program Chair.

Late Work Policy:
It is the student's responsibility to meet all deadlines for class assignments. Grades for each late

assignment submitted may be penalized by 20%. It is up to the professor whether they will accept late work. It is your responsibility to communicate with the professor in a timely manner regarding late work and absences.

Mechanics of the Course:

A) Class Sessions
Class sessions will be used for a variety of purposes including:
Lecture
Class and Group Discussion
Diagnostic practice
Examinations

B) Exams
Final Exam- Diagnostic Case Vignette: There is one written exam in this course. The exam will require students to provide an accurate diagnosis based on information gathered from a vignette provided by the professor. In the response, students will describe symptoms that meet diagnostic criteria, provide an accurate diagnosis and thorough differential diagnosis using all the steps of differential diagnosis, and a basic treatment plan. A rubric for the exam is provided at the end of the syllabus.
THIS IS A KEY ASSESSMENT: This exam serves as one of the key assessments for the program and is used to evaluate entry level diagnostic skills. As such, students must pass the exam to receive a passing grade in the class. Given the significance of the exam, students who do not pass the exam will be offered the opportunity to engage in remediation of skills and retake the exam.

C) Response, Research, or Other Written Assignments

Case Vignettes
Students select a mental health disorder from the readings covered in each class session and write a detailed vignette that includes the following:

- A brief description of the client including mental status, relevant mental health, medical, personal history and demographic information.
- A detailed description of symptoms relevant to mental health disorder selected. The description of symptoms should allow classmates to confirm or rule out a diagnosis
- A properly formatted DSM diagnosis for the case.

Vignettes are due before class and will be posted to discovery.
Additionally, students will need to bring a copy of the vignette to share in class. The copy shared in class should not include the DSM diagnosis as it will be used as a part of an in-class exercise which will require students to evaluate the vignette and provide an accurate diagnosis.

Case Vignette are due on the following Dates:

- Vignette 1- 1/27/2026

- Vignette 2- 2/10/26
- Vignette 3- 2/24/26
- Vignette 4- 3/10/26
- Vignette 5- 3/24/26

Clinical Interview Video- Due March 25
Students will work with a partner to take turns recording a clinical interview role play. For this project, each student will take the role of the clinician and the client.
As the clinician, the student must conduct a brief, 10-minute diagnostic interview using the skills covered in the course. The aim of the assignment is to practice asking open and closed questions to explore the client's experience with symptoms that may help inform a diagnosis. NOTE- a diagnosis is not required as the time frame for the interview is limited. Rather, the exercise is the demonstration of skills related to the clinical interview.

As the client, the student will role play one of the characters created from the case vignettes. The student should be prepared to answer clinical interview questions that help lead to greater understanding of symptoms and a possible diagnosis. Therefore, the student should be familiar with the client's history and history of the illness (IE, onset, duration and frequency of symptoms, severity, any related specifiers, etc.).

The video may be recorded via Microsoft Stream or Teams. Students will save the video to their NU One Drive and share the link with the professor by submitting a document with the link to Discovery.
See. Discovery for more details.

D) Participation

A portion of the student's final grade will be based on their participation in class and group discussions, in class exercises, individual and group presentations, and attendance. Full points will be rewarded to those students who attend all class sessions and actively participate in class activities.

E) Grading

Vignettes will be graded within a week of being submitted and/or prior to when the next vignette is due. Exams and clinical interview videos will be graded within 2 weeks. If you have concerns about grading timing, please check with the professor, program coordinator, or program Chair.

The students course grade will be based upon her/his mastery of course terms, concept, and objections as demonstrated by classroom attendance, participation, presentations, and papers. Please be on time with all assignments, if late, there will be a deduction of grade points. Grading is conducted on the Discovery Grade Book page of the course. Students are expected to monitor their progress.

Grading Scale:

A	100-94%	C	76-74%
A-	93-90%	C-	73-70%

B+	89-87%	D+	69-67%
B	86-84%	D	66-64%
B-	83-80%	D-	63-60%
C+	79-77%	F	59% and below

F) Course Values

Item		***Point Value***
Case Vignettes	10 points each x 5	50 points
Final Exam- Diagnostic Vignette		100 points
Diagnostic Interview		30 Points
Class Attendance/Participation		20 points
		Total: 200 points

G) Lecture, Reading, and Assignment Outline

This guide serves as an outline for the course. Included is a recommendation for weekly reading as well as descriptions of topics and assignments for class sessions. Please refer to Discovery for detailed instructions for assignments, reading, and specific due dates for this course. Dates for specific lecture topics may change and material may need to be added or deleted. If any changes are made, they will be announced in class.

Week/Date	***Reading***	***Topics***	***Assignments Due***	***CACREP Standards Met/Covered***
January 5-9 Class Session Jan. 9 (1)	Castonguay and Oltmanns: Chapters 1, 2, 3 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading *** See Discovery for Optional Resources.	Introduction to Psychopathology, Depression, Generalized Anxiety		5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a

January 12-16 Class Session Jan.13 (2)	Morrison Chapters 1-4	Introduction to Psychopathology, Depression, Generalized Anxiety, Clinical interview opening, chief complaint, developing rapport, managing the interview	Vignette #1 Due	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
January 19-23	Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 4 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Generalized Anxiety, Panic Disorder Intro to diagnosing		5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
January 26-30 Class Session Jan.27 (3)	Morrison Chapters 5-8 Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 5 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Clinical Interviewing- History of present illness, fact collecting, feelings, personal and social history, obsessive compulsive disorders	Case Vignette #2	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a

Feb. 2-6	Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 6 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Post traumatic stress,		5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
February 9-13 **Class Session Feb.10 (4)**	Morrison Ch 9-12 Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 7 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Differential Diagnosis, Clinical Interviewing- sensitive subjects, mental status exam, Eating disorders	Case Vignette #3	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a

February 18-20	Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 8 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading Required Article: Trice, P. D., & Bjorck, J. P. (2006). Pentecostal perspectives on causes and cures of depression. Professional Psychology: Research and Practice, 37(3), 283–294. doi:10.1037/0735-7028.37.3.283	Substance related disorders Spiritual perspectives of mental heath	Case Vignette #4	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
February 23-27 Class Session Feb. 24 (5)	Morrison Chapter 13 Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 9 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Cultural Considerations, Spiritual Personality Disorders Clinical interviewing practice	Case Vignette #4	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a

March 2-6	Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 10 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Bipolar disorders		5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
March 9-13 **Class Session Mar. 10 (6)**	Morrison Chapters 17-20 Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 11 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Case Formulation, Treatment planning, Schizophrenia related disorders, Differential diagnosis and clinical interviewing practice	Case Vignette #5	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
March 16-20	Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 12 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Marial relationship discord,		5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a

March 23-27 **Class Session March 24 (7)**	Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 13, 14 DSM- Review Diagnostic criterial, diagnostic features, differential diagnosis sections for disorders coved in this week's reading	Sexual dysfunction, sleep wake disorders, Differential diagnosing final exam- prep	Clinical Interview Video Due	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
March 30-April 3	Castonguay, Oltmanns, Power Lott- Chapters 15 &16	Suicide, Differential diagnosing final exam- prep		5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a
April 6-10 **Class Session April 7**		Differential diagnosing final exam	Final Exam In class	5C.1.c 5C.2.b 5C.2.d 5C.3.a KPI-7

Final Exam Rubric

Criteria	Excels In all Criteria	Meets most Criteria	Meets Some Criteria	Criteria Not Met
Approximate Range	**A**	**B + to A-**	**B- to B+**	**Below B-**
Accurate Diagnosis	Includes accurate DSM Diagnosis with all specifiers, detailed and accurate description of how symptoms meet diagnostic criteria	Includes accurate diagnosis but incomplete specifiers, description of how symptoms meet diagnostic criteria	Includes accurate diagnosis but missing or incorrect specifies, limited and description of how symptoms meet diagnostic criteria	Includes inaccurate/incomplete diagnosis, diagnosis missing, inaccurate or missing description of how symptoms meet diagnostic criteria
Differential Diagnosis	Includes all steps of differential diagnosis, accurate and thorough differential diagnosis of disorders relevant to case, detailed description of how symptoms differ from diagnostic criteria of other disorders	Includes all steps of differential diagnosis, accurate differential diagnosis of some disorders relevant to the case, a limited description of how symptoms differ from diagnostic criteria of other disorders	Some but not all steps of differential diagnosis included, differential diagnosis is partially accurate, limited or inaccurate description of how symptoms differ from diagnostic criteria of other disorders	Missing, incomplete, inaccurate differential diagnosis, incorrect or missing description of how symptoms differ from diagnostic criteria of other disorders
Treatment Planning	Clear and relevant treatment plan based on evidence based treatments, description of rational for treatment	Treatment plan is included, based on evidence based treatment, adequate rational provided	Treatment plan included but lacks clarity, some evident based treatments included, rational limited	Treatment plan not included, not based on evidence rational not included or grossly inaccurate.